

Integrative Thinking

Roger Martin

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*Image Source: *The Opposable Mind*, by Roger Martin

F. Scott Fitzgerald

“The test of first-rate intelligence is the ability to hold two opposing ideas in mind at the same time and still retain the ability to function...”



Integrative Thinking

Salience – the conventional approach is to discard as many as possible – or not even to consider some of them in the first place. In order to reduce our exposure to uncomfortable complexity, we filter out salient features when considering an issue. We also do this because of how most organizations are structured. Each functional specialty has its own narrow view of what merits consideration.

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Causality - In the second step of decision making, you analyze how the numerous salient factors relate to one another. Conventional thinkers tend to take the same narrow view of causality that they do of salience. The simplest type of all is a straight-line causal relationship. The integrative thinker isn't afraid to question the validity of apparently obvious links or to consider multidirectional and nonlinear relationships.

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Architecture - The order in which you make these decisions will affect the outcome. Integrative Thinkers don't break down a problem into independent pieces and work on them separately or in a certain order. They see the entire architecture of the problem – how the various parts of it fit together, how one decision will affect another. Just as important, they hold all of those pieces suspended in their minds at once.

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Resolution - All of these stages – determining what is salient, analyzing the causal relationships between the salient factors, examining the architecture of the problem – lead to an outcome. Too often, we accept an unpleasant trade-off with relatively little complaint, since it appears to be the best alternative. When a satisfactory outcome does emerge, though, it is inevitably due to the leader's refusal to accept trade-offs and conventional options.

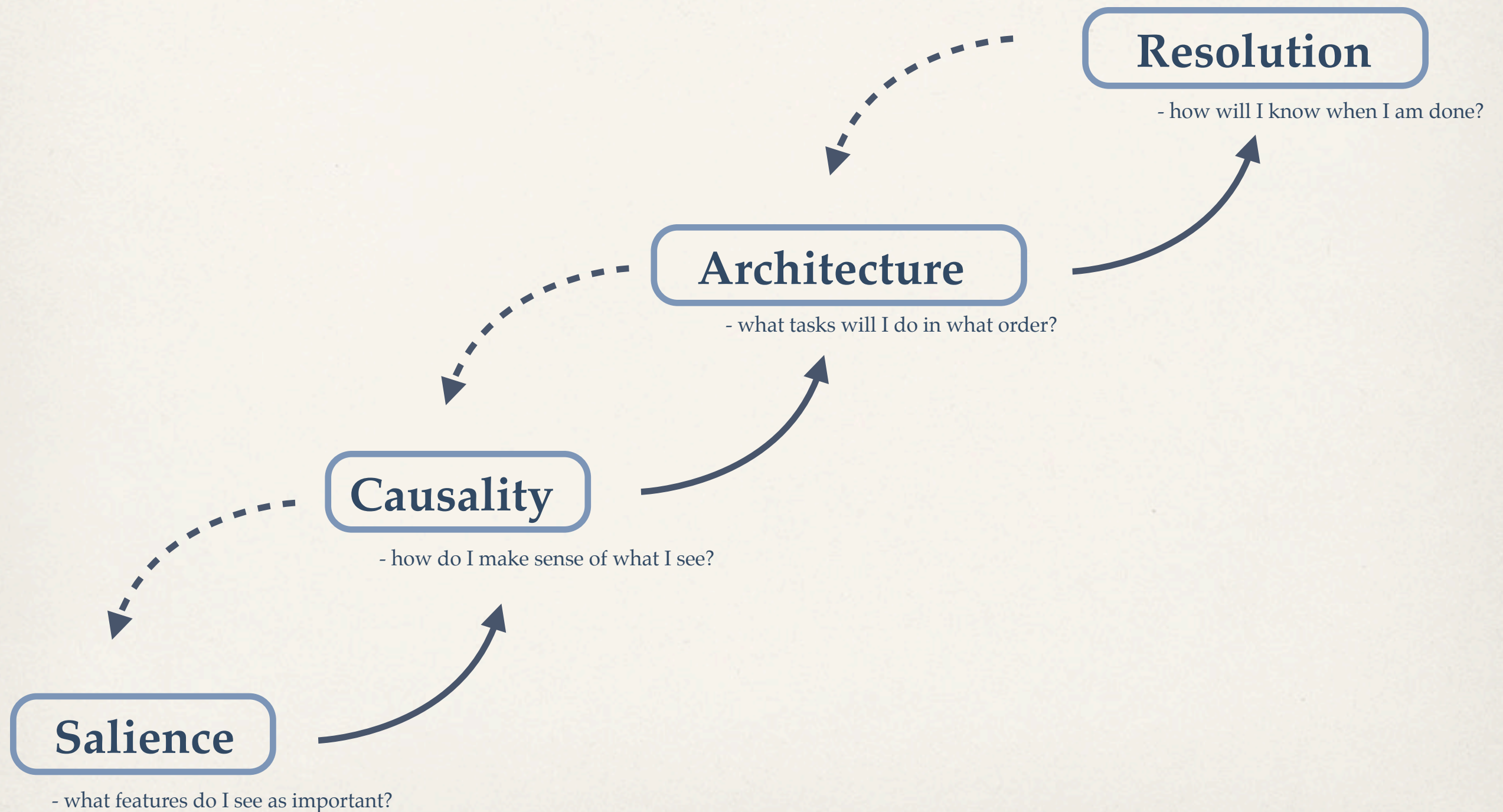
Salience - what features do I see as important?

Causality - how do I make sense of what I see?

Architecture - what tasks will I do in what order?

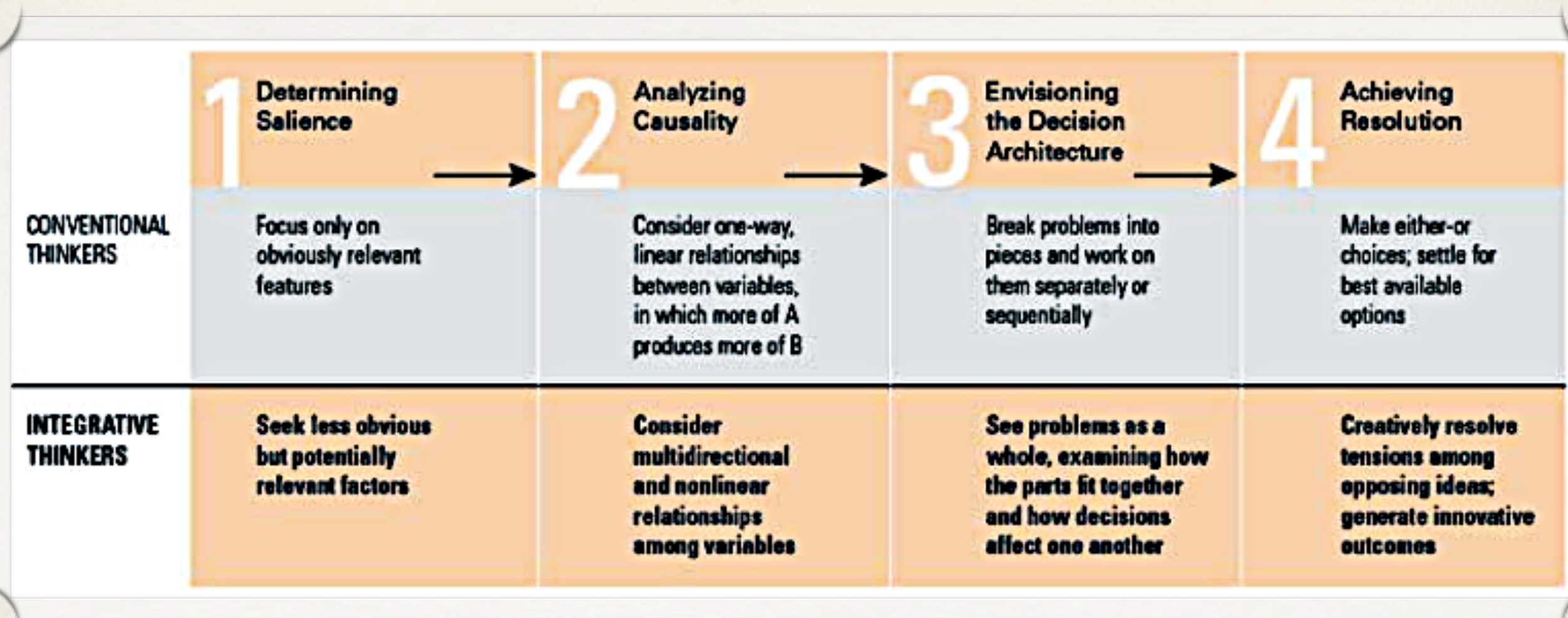
Resolution - how will I know when I am done?

Integrative Thinking



*Source: *The Opposable Mind*, Roger Martin, p.29

Conventional vs. Integrative



“The integrative thinkers I interviewed have learned to change their factory settings and distinguish between reality and models that purport to reflect reality.”

Stance

Tools

Experiences

Stance

Tools

Experiences

Stance is how you see the world around you,
but it's also how you see yourself in that
world.

Stance

Tools

Experiences

Tools range from formal theories to established processes to rules of thumb. Your stance guides what tools you choose to accumulate.

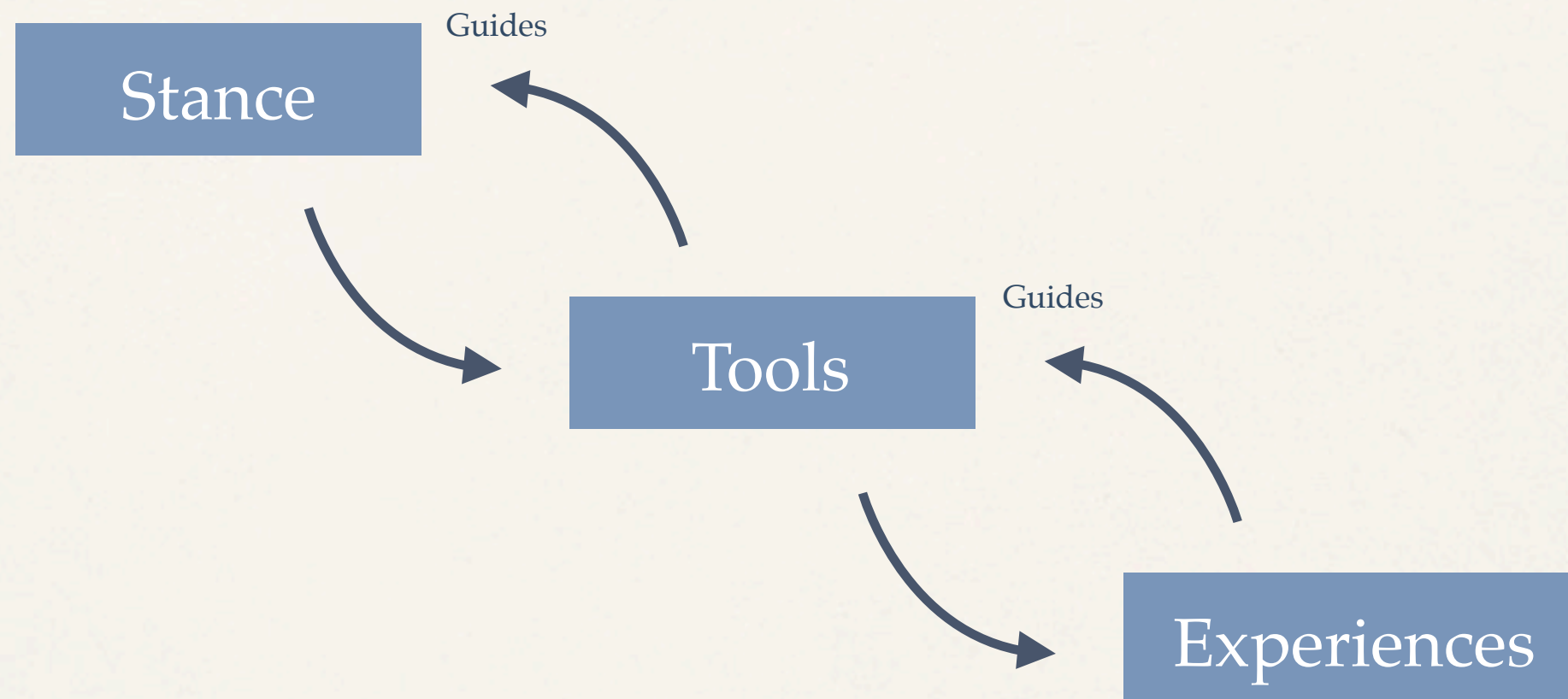
Stance

Tools

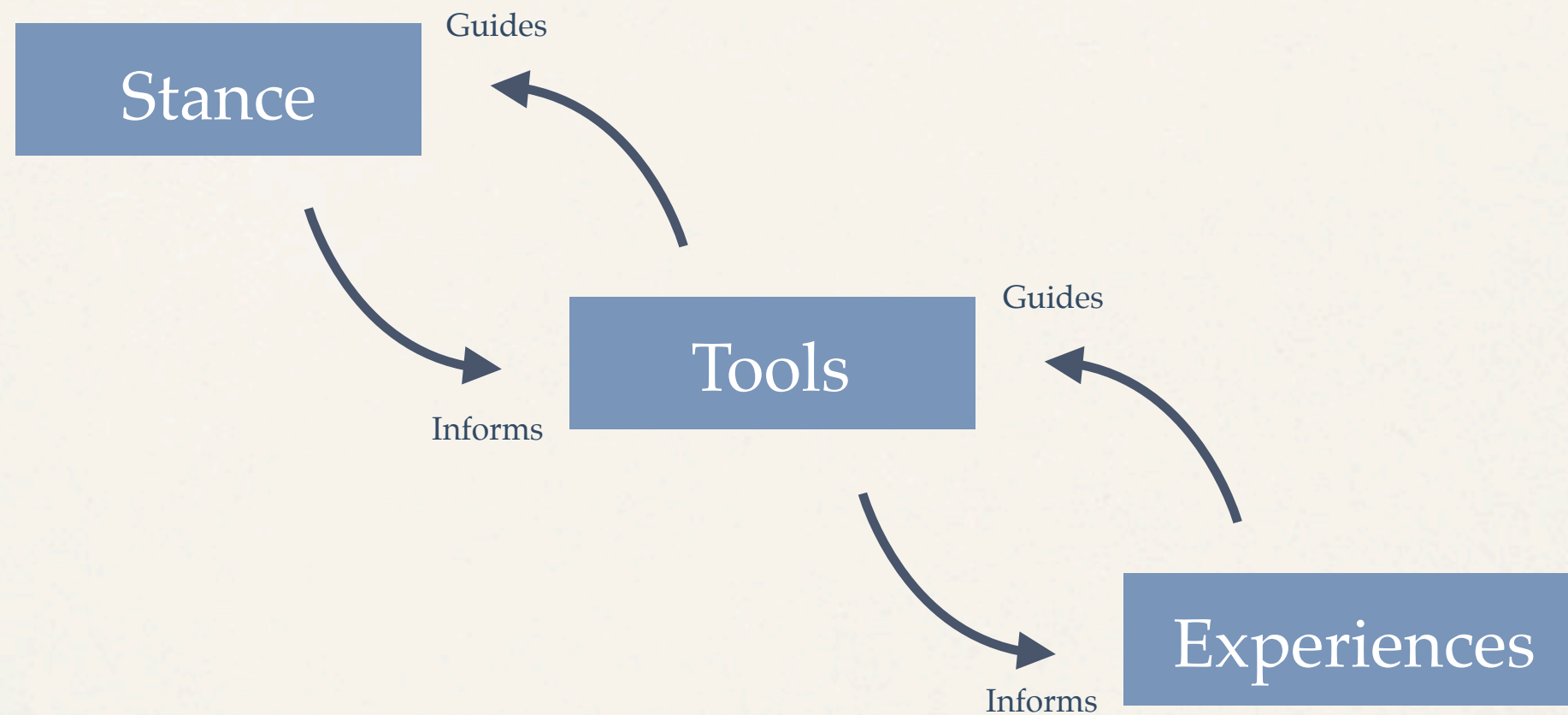
Experiences

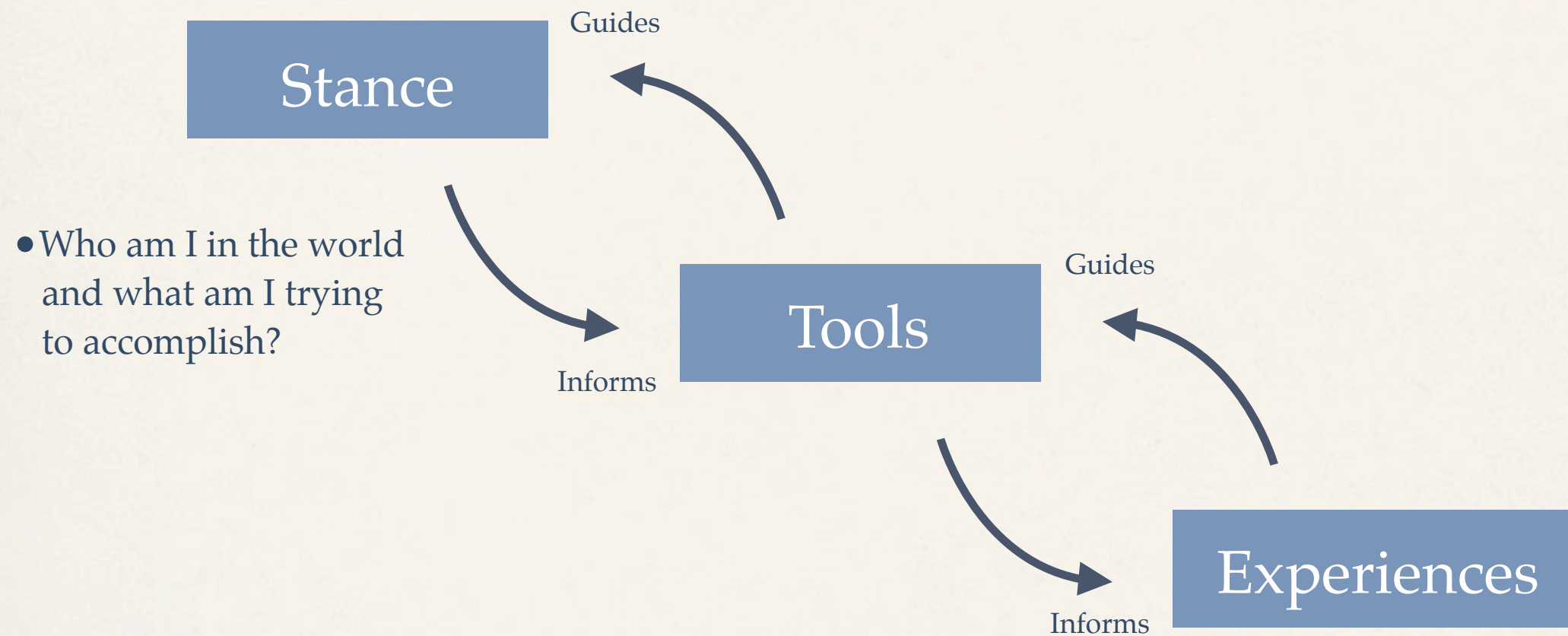
The experiences you accumulate are the product of your stance and tools, which guide you toward some experiences and away from others.

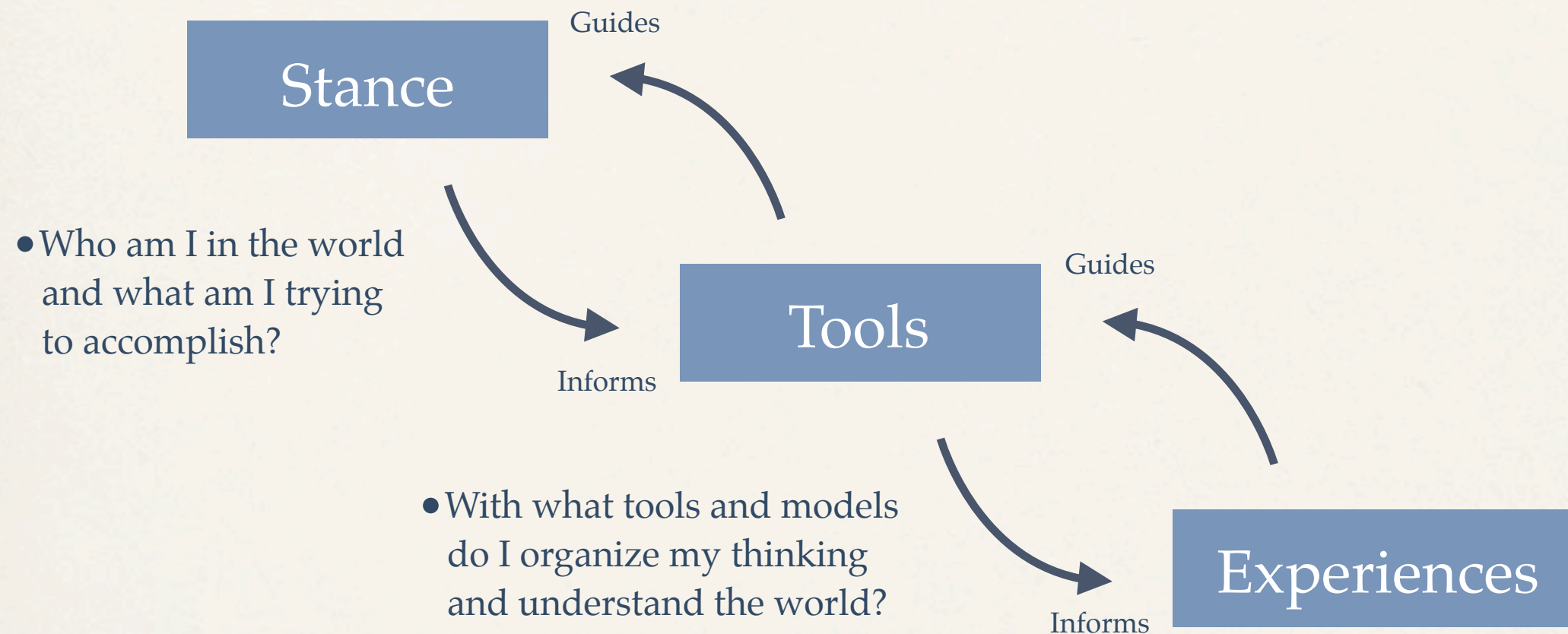
Knowledge Model



Knowledge Model







Knowledge Model

